

By Abhijit Dasgupta

For some time now, West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya has not been keeping well. After a cabinet meeting, when he was having a puff in the corridors of the secretariat, one of his ministerial colleagues, Kiranmoy Nanda, asked him seriously, "I wonder why you don't give up this vile habit? It's ruining your health." Bhattacharya looked at him askance and smiled with the petulance of an errant kid. "Come on, check for yourself. The three men, Churchill, Roosevelt and Stalin, who won the Second World War, were all heavy smokers. Why should I give up smoking?"

This episode summarises Bhattacharya's dilemma. After nine years as chief minister, the 65-year-old communist now sees an empire in ruins but takes pride and sometimes even wallows in his belief that whatever he has been doing may be just short of perfect but is good all the same. As scandals rock his Government, partners criticise him openly and cadres point a finger at his ineptitude in handling matters of crucial importance, the man who rules Bengal will not show that he is wrong. His body language has changed dramatically over the last few months; the spring in his step and the arrogant faraway look of the poet is missing now. Bhattacharya, however, won't give in or say he is at fault and that an abler man could have handled the situation better. Sadly, that is not what is expected of the man who holds the most responsible position, and by default, the most powerful rank in West Bengal.

Left Front (LF) chairman Biman Bose, a few years older than Bhattacharya and a close associate for 40-odd years, is himself looking worn out and sick these days. "I am just back from a meeting; maybe that is why I am not looking okay," he says on the last day of the Pujas. Asked about Bhattacharya, Bose, however, speaks at length. "He has been at the forefront of the Communist movement since he graduated from Presidency College in 1964. He has always been a stellar organiser. The

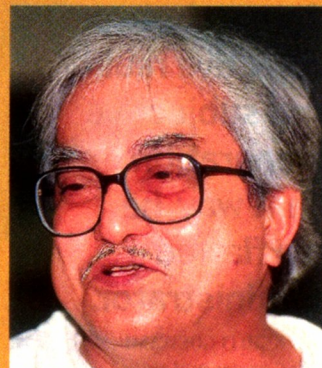
way he organised the anti-US movement in Kolkata against the bombing of Vietnam in the late '60s is something we still use as a reference point. In 1993, when he quit the ministry in a huff, we all felt bad at what we thought was his recklessness. But Buddha realised his mistake and like a true communist returned to become minister again," says Bose of his comrade-in-arms.

Asked why the communists are going downhill under the stewardship of Bhattacharya, Bose, who is also secretary of the state CPI(M), said, "Buddha has to realise that it is important to reach out to the masses. There are certain definitive issues he has to address. I think his problem is that he feels that the masses will automatically understand that what is being done is only for their welfare and not otherwise. He is a widely misunderstood man."

To worsen Bhattacharya's problems, even top industrialists, his mainstay till the other day and a segment he had assiduously wooed till the fall of Singur and Nano, seem to be leaving him. While RPG vice-president Sanjeev Goenka still feels that Bhattacharya is an "outstanding chief minister," one top captain of industry very close to the chief minister but who refused to be named, said, "When Bhattacharya first set the industry bandwagon rolling, his slogan was that we were late starters. It was an honest appraisal and we understood it and respected him for that admission, assuring him full support. He brought back confidence in the industry. But problems started later. The gap between intent and communication became his main problem. He wanted something, and his party went ahead and ensured that something different happened. Bhattacharya had no control over that and that led to his downfall. His slogan Destination Bengal has now become a mockery of a brand name."

The problems though were biting into the party's entrails since the late '90s. The main success of the Front since it came to power in 1977 and through the '80s and into the '90s had been land reforms and de-

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has become the embodiment of failure but still refuses to accept reality.